PHL204: Philosophy in Everyday Life

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Outline

Mind-swapping problem for Psychological Continuity Theory

Transporter Paradox

Today's question

Intrinsic v instrumental

Death is Bad for your Survivors

Deprivation Account

Challenges for the Deprivation Account

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Mind-swapping



Imagine a scientist swaps all of person A's psychological data (memories, dreams, beliefs etc) with person B's

After the procedure, one of the bodies will be tortured and the other will be given $1 million

Suppose we ask person A before the mind-swap: which body do you pick to get tortured after the mind-swap?

What should they answer?

Mind-swapping



Imagine a scientist is going to hook you up to a machine that will drive you insane by deleting all of your memories and beliefs etc

Then the scientist is going to implant a whole new set of memories and beliefs in you

After the procedure, the scientist will torture you

Will you be afraid in that situation? why or why not?

Mind-swapping

If you think the two situations are different, then what makes them different?

Mind-swapping

This is a thought-experiment from philosopher Bernard Williams

He thinks that there is no difference between the mind-swap experiment and the being-driven-insane experiment

But if we feel afraid in the second case, then we shouldn't think that mind-swapping actually changes our personal identity

Rather, what matters for personal identity is what body we are in

Mind-swapping

Naturally, if bodily continuity doesn't matter, then you should pick body A to be tortured after the minds has been swapped with body B

But can you be sure that you want body A to be tortured? In the second thought experiment that is your body!

If you are comfortable with body A being tortured after the procedure, then you are buying into a psychological continuity theory of personal identity

Mind-swapping

If you are comfortable with body A being tortured after the procedure, then you are buying into a psychological continuity theory of personal identity

So, then, what problems are there with the psychological theory?

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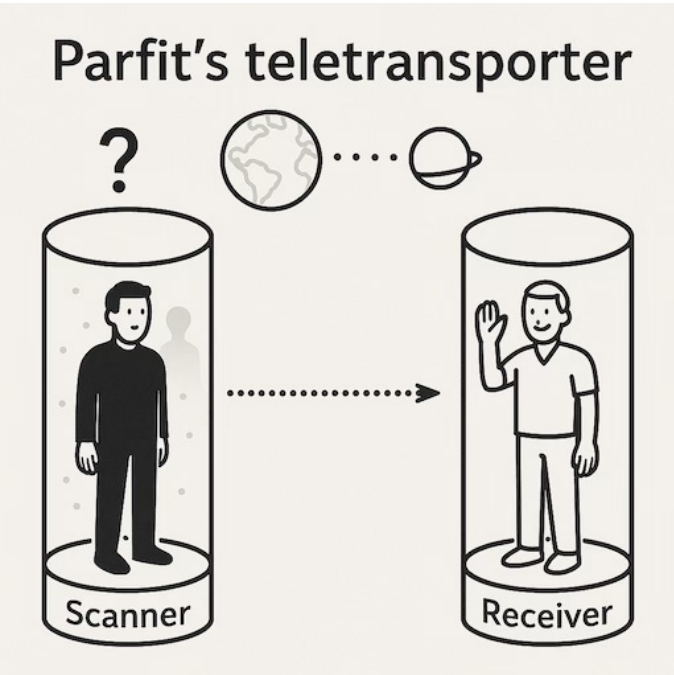
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The setup



Imagine we have the Star Trek teleportation machine that can teleport anyone from here to Mars almost instantaneously

It makes an atom-for-atom duplicate of you on Mars while destroying your physical body here

The person that steps out of the teleportation machine is psychologically continuous with you

Supervenience

A supervenes on B if:

- Same B $\rightarrow$ same A

Two ways of thinking about this:

- Once you fix the B-facts, you fix the A-facts
- You cannot change the A-facts without first changing the B-facts

Supervenience



Consider: an original Picasso painting vs. a perfect forgery

- Is the forgery equally beautiful?
- Is the forgery equally valuable?

Beauty supervenes on paint placement—so duplicating the paint placement means that you duplicate the beauty

Value does not supervene on paint placement—so duplicating the paint placement does not mean that you duplicate the value

Supervenience

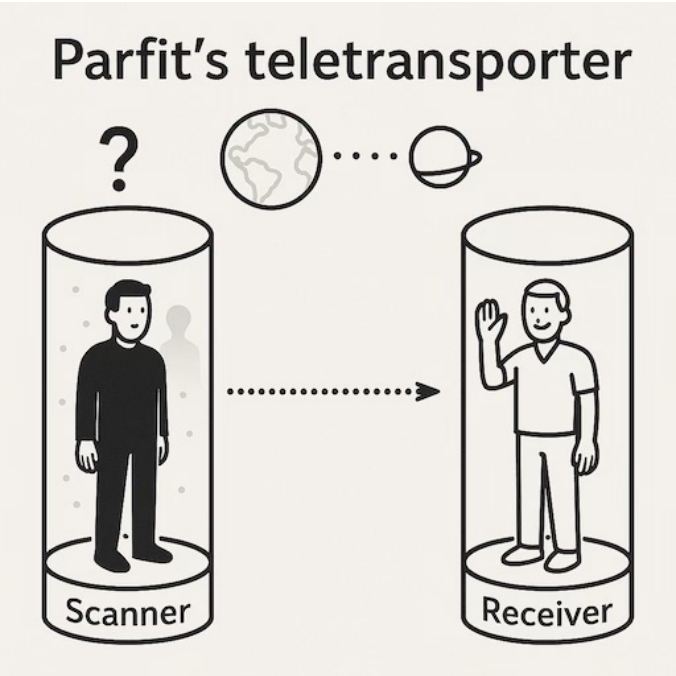
Other examples of supervenience relations:

- The economy supervenes on individual transactions
- Music supervenes on soundwaves
- Flavor supervenes on chemical makeup

Examples of non-supervenience relations:

- Currency does not supervene on physical items (like coins)
- Legal judgment does not supervene on physical actions

Supervenience



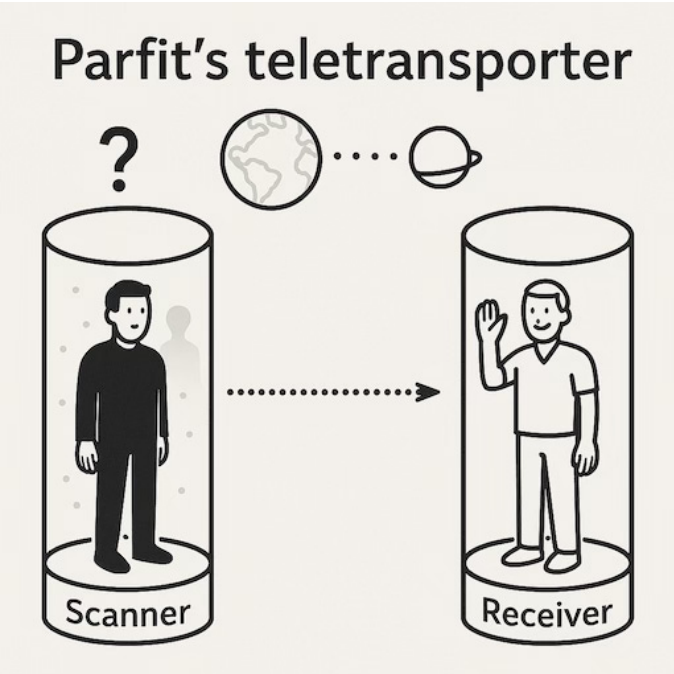
A standard supervenience claim about the mind:

Same physical properties $\rightarrow$ same mental properties

In other words, mental properties supervene on physical properties

This is why the physical duplicate that steps out of the machine on Mars is psychologically continuous with you

The problem



Suppose the machine malfunctions and it creates two exact duplicates of you, one duplicate of you on the Moon and another on Mars

There are now two physical duplicates of you

Both are psychologically continuous with you but how can both be identical with you?

Options

There are only three options about personal identity in this situation:

1. You are identical to both persons: the person on earth and the person that steps out of the machine on Mars
2. You are identical to just one of these persons
3. You are identical to neither of them

Option 1: You are identical to both

The problem with this option is that you cannot be identical to both because immediately after stepping outside of the machine, each of the two persons will start forming new memories that will be different from each other



Option 2: You are identical to just one

The problem with this option is that you cannot be identical to just one because that is arbitrary

How would you pick which one is you and which one is not you? Do you flip a coin? That doesn't seem to be how personal identity should work!

Option 3: You are identical to neither

The problem with this option is that it goes against the psychological continuity theory of identity

After all, if the machine hadn't malfunctioned, and there was only one body that stepped out of the teleporter somewhere, then the theory says that person is you

So, how can we be identical to neither? How could some independent event millions of miles away affect your personal identity?

If a single teleportation is successful, then how could a double success be a failure?

No identity at all?

If you are not identical to one, both, or neither then perhaps personal identity is not a stable concept

But how then do we make sense of the difference between my memories and your memories, don't we need the concept of identity to define memory?

No identity at all?

Moreover, should we really give up the idea of personal identity?

One of the reasons we care deeply about personal identity is because we give so much significance to death: the point at which your life ends...

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The question

Is death bad for you?

What the question is asking

Two separate questions we may wonder about here:

- Is death a harm done to you?
- And if it is, how can it be a harm if you are dead?

What the question is asking

Kagan and Nagel both think that death is bad for you

Their goal is to figure out how it could possibly be bad to be dead given that it is so obvious that it is bad for you

What the question is asking

This may give us pause:

Is it so obvious that death is bad for you?

- One approach: absurdism—life has no meaning, so why is death so bad?
- Another approach: religious—there is an afterlife, so why worry about death?

Potential answers

Kagan considers four possible answers:

1. Death is bad for you intrinsically
2. Death is bad for you instrumentally
3. Death is not bad for you, it is bad for those that survive you
4. Death is bad for you comparatively

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Intrinsic v instrumental

Intrinsic: in virtue of itself

Instrumental: in virtue of some other element

Intrinsic

Kagan's example: pain is an intrinsic harm

It is bad for you in virtue of itself



Instrumental

Kagan's example: being poor is an instrumental harm

It is bad for in virtue of the fact that being poor usually leads to suffering

Being poor is a way of getting to harm, not harmful itself (though we may disagree with Kagan here!)



The problem

Kagan quickly dismisses these two options

Death cannot be either an intrinsic or an instrumental harm to you if you are dead

After all, who is being harmed intrinsically or instrumentally if you are dead?

Existence requirement

This raises what Kagan calls the existence requirement

Some properties can only be attributed to you if you actually exist

Facing an intrinsic or instrumental harm is one of those properties: if you are dead, i.e., you don't exist then how can you be facing these harms?

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Death is bad for those that survive you

On this view, one might argue that death is not bad for you

If there is any harm at all that happens on your death, it is a harm to those that are separated from you by your death, i.e., your friends, family etc

Death is bad for those that survive you

After all, given the existence requirement you are no longer around

So, perhaps you are not harmed at all, and the harm we associate with death is just a harm that the people around you suffer

Kagan is going to argue against this by developing a counterexample

Counterexamples

In general, conditional claims take the following form:

If X, then Y

How do we show that this claim is false?

Counterexamples

Suppose I make the following conditional claim:

If it is raining, then Tina will have an umbrella

What would it take for this to be false?



Counterexamples

To show that the conditional claim (If X, then Y) is false:

Find a counterexample: a situation in which the antecedent is true but the consequent is false

The antecedent: X

The consequent: Y

So if there is a situation in which *it is raining* but *Tina does not have an umbrella* then that particular conditional claim is false

Death is bad for those that survive you



Setup

- Your friend is taking off on a century long space journey
- Everyone they know on Earth will be dead by the time they return

Death is bad for those that survive you



Scenario 1

You lose all radio contact with the ship 20 minutes after take-off and you never hear from your friend again

Death is bad for those that survive you



Scenario 2

The spaceship explodes 20 minutes after take-off and everyone on board dies

Death is bad for those that survive you

Are these two scenarios the same?

Kagan argues that the second scenario is worse

But if so, then it can't be that all the harm in death is just about separation from those that survive you, because separation happens in both scenarios

Death is bad for those that survive you

The conditional claim:

If you leave behind survivors, then this is why death is bad for you

Antecedent: if you leave behind survivors

Consequent: then this is why death is bad for you

Here Kagan has developed a counterexample to this theory on why death is bad for you

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Death is bad for you comparatively

This is the option that both Nagel and Kagan take most seriously

On this view, death is bad for you because you lose out on something that you would have had if you had not died: more life!

There is an opportunity cost to death

Death is bad for you comparatively

This is known as the deprivation account of the harm of death

Death is bad for you because of what it deprives you of

In other words, death is bad for you because you miss out

Opportunity cost

What exactly is it that it is harmful to miss out on?

Suppose Tina goes into a coma for 20 years and then passes away before ever regaining full consciousness

Did those extra 20 years make a difference? Is this an opportunity cost we wouldn't want to miss out on?



Opportunity cost

Nagel disagrees:

He thinks that most of us wouldn't think there is much difference between dying now and going into a coma for 20 years and then dying

So, it can't be just any life that we don't want to miss out on: it has to be a life in which we gain meaningful experience

Opportunity cost

In dying you are deprived of time you could have had with your family and friends, making art, traveling, developing skills, enjoying books, music etc etc

Whatever it is that we might find meaningful, it will be part of what we miss out on by dying

So this is why death is bad for you

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Challenges

The deprivation account faces three challenges:

1. How can you be deprived of something if you are unaware of it?
2. When exactly are you harmed if you are dead?
3. What about all that you were deprived of before you were born?

Awareness and deprivation

First problem: how can you be deprived of X if you are not aware of X? After all, we are not aware of anything at at all in death!

One might object that what matters is not the deprivation itself but that we are around to be aware of and mind the deprivation

If we are not aware of being deprived of life, then could this really be a harm?

Awareness and deprivation

In general, are you harmed if you are not aware of the harm?

Question: suppose your best friend lies to you about something significant but you never find out and it never affects your relationship in any way

Question: suppose your significant other cheats on you but you never find out and it never affects your relationship in any way

Have you been harmed in these scenarios?

Awareness and deprivation

You might reply:

The reason these scenarios are still harmful is because there remains a possibility that you could become aware of the deception

It is just a contingent matter that you never find out

So perhaps what matters is deprivation that isn't just contingent

Awareness and deprivation

Suppose you sustain a brain injury that means you regress to having the mental life of a 3-year-old

This is permanent

You live a contented life, but you have been deprived of being an adult

This is a catastrophe!



Awareness and deprivation

In this case you have gone from a responsible adult to having the mind of a child

You never find out about it and it cannot be changed

Surely, you have been harmed here, and harmed in a really significant way

We treat these cases as tragedies!

Awareness and deprivation

You might reply:

The reason this situation is harmful is because you are still alive to be deprived of something

But could we really be harmed when we are dead?

Awareness and deprivation

Scenario

Suppose after your death a rumor spreads that all the books you said you wrote were written actually by your brother instead

Are you not being harmed here even after your death?

Awareness and deprivation

Scenario

Suppose your parent commits you to a promise on their deathbed, but after they die, you think:

They are dead, it doesn't matter if I keep this promise, it's not like they can be harmed anyway

Is it true that the parent is not harmed in this situation?